

create the full image. By printing in achromatic tones, the work serves as an unfinished map, inviting viewers to interpret and complete the image. The woodblock, archived from the Diamond Library, the last remaining publishing house in Bat-tala, operating since 1877, bridges past and present through the act of reprinting. "The piece challenges traditional authorship, inviting collective participation from the artist, the original carver and the viewer," he elaborates.

Mixed-media artist Debasish Mukherjee's work 'Mirror-Land' recounts the stories of people from across the border who settled in various camps in India following the anti-Hindu riots in East Pakistan in 1950. Debasish conversed with many individuals who had lost their homes in 'Opar Bangla'. "The interviews imprinted vivid, layered images in my mind," he says.

Running alongside the exhibition, a printmaking workshop is being held on September 21-22, followed by a seminar on September 26, where art enthusiasts can delve deeper into the history of Bat-tala prints. The exhibition is on from September 13 to 27, at the India International Centre (IIC), New Delhi. ■

–Neha Kirpal



From extreme left, actor Dharmendra in *Shalimar* (1978), and Ustad Bade Ghulam Ali Khan (1965)

says Baskar. "You had all these camera clubs across the country and they all conducted workshops, lessons and so on. This was also how he entered the field, so he was always clear that teaching and pedagogy were central to what he wanted to achieve with photography." ■

–Aditya Mani Jha

EXHIBITION

A PRINT STORY

The exhibition*, Past in Perspective: Printmaking Practices in India, *chronicles the journey of print in India



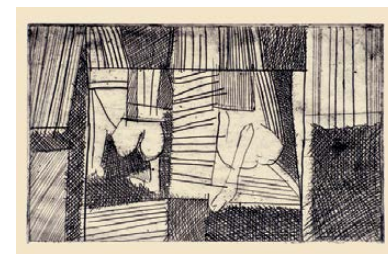


(From left) Swapan Kumar Das's linocut 'Survivor', Rabindranath Tagore's etching 'Untitled', and K.G. Subramanyan's etching 'Untitled'

The printing press only became a reality in India in the 16th century, with the first one set up by colonial settlers in Goa. Five centuries on, printmaking in India has not only evolved but has also become a subject of scholarship and a medium of fine art. It's now the focus of a group exhibition by Akar Prakar Gallery, Kolkata, titled *Past in Perspective: Printmaking Practices in India*, which is on display till September 28, 2024.

"Printmaking in India started with the printing of books and dailies, [going on] to become a medium of political protest, since these could be easily multiplied and distributed without the authorities getting to know," says Abhijit Lath, co-director, Akar Prakar. The gallery has a history of celebrating print cultures in different ways. "Our first show 20 years ago was a prints show of Laxma Goud. Some of the first things we sold were prints," says Lath. On display at the show are the works of artists like Anupam Sud, Arun Bose, Benode Behari Mukherjee, Chittaprosad, Gaganendranath Tagore, Rabindranath Tagore, Ramkinkar Baij and Nandalal Bose, among others. Each artist on the list marks a pivotal point in the history of printmaking in India.

For example, the three Tagore brothers and nephews of Rabindranath—Abanindranath, Gaganendranath and Samarendranath—founded the Bichitra Club in Calcutta in 1915. It became a studio for artistic experimentation in painting and printmaking, with Gaganendranath publishing his first album of lithographic prints, *Adbhut Lok* (The Realm of the Absurd), in 1917. In the years that followed, many artists, including Rabindranath himself, associated with the Bichitra Club, besides Mukul Dey and Bose, who were experimenting with printmaking.



The printmaking practices exhibition, **PAST IN PERSPECTIVE**, is on at AkarPrakar Gallery, Kolkata, till Sept. 28

Lath mentions how Chittaprosad's works were a revelation for the gallery while curating the show. "The famine works by Chittaprosad, who was self-taught, were a striking discovery. He had such empathy in his protest," says Lath.

By the early 1980s, printmaking departments were established in the leading art schools across the country. The exhibition surveys these cultures that have lent a physical form to the country's oral storytelling traditions. ■

–Arshia